

K. Elango

“Attending classes is a waste of time. What I learn in a one-hour lecture, I can grasp in five minutes from YouTube. I am better informed of the latest trends in a flawless and fluent presentation.” This statement from my college-going son during a conversation disturbed me deeply.

While the claim may be true in his case, it gave rise to a nagging question: ‘Why do learners remain at the same level of academic competence throughout the 12 years of schooling?’ This led to a close observation of the performance patterns of students passing through our system.

Even if we categorise students as advanced, average and mediocre, ideally, as they progress through the educational ladder, their capabilities should be enhanced as a result of the teaching-learning processes. But their performances remain static, especially in the latter two categories. This leads to the question: Does the teacher-learner interface really make any difference?

Mismatch exists
Several pedagogical methods – inquiry-based, project-based, and activity-based learning – were adopted to make learning effective for all. Further, shifts to learner-centric and communicative approaches were trumpeted



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How learners learn

If every student is to be a productive learner, a paradigm shift from generic delivery to individualised mode is essential

as leading to a better learning ecosystem. Despite all this, the mismatch between teaching and learning exists, which is evident as the three categories of learners largely continue to persist.

The myth of learner learns what teacher teaches has been debunked. Following textbooks and attentively listening doesn’t automatically result in learning. The oft-quoted, “If they can’t learn the way we teach, we need to teach the way they learn” demands an urgent transformational trajectory.

At the high-school level, students must be made aware of what learning is and how to learn. They must be steered to reflect metacognitively and identify whether they are visual learners, auditory learners, or kinesthetic learners. This shift calls for teachers to use multi-modal approaches, even within a 40-minute class period, alongside the prescribed text. Other print texts such as excerpts from newspapers and magazines, e-texts in multiple formats such as blogs,

vlogs, infographics, videos, film clips, reels, and music must feature in every class to keep all the learners hooked. Such a practice validates Howard Gardner’s concept of multiple intelligences and facilitates different learners benefiting from the varieties of texts, clubbed with multiple activities.

The architecture of educational institutions with rows of classrooms, each stacked with benches and desks, scarcely provides any space for learner-centred engagements. It is solely designed for teach-

er-centric modes. Yet, the open spaces within campuses allow us to adopt Tagore’s visionary model of Santiniketan. The availability of classrooms need not restrict students, as they eagerly welcome activities conducted outdoors.

Linguistic skills
There is also the issue of acquisition of linguistic skills: speaking can be learnt only by speaking, writing only writing, listening by listening and reading by reading. The lament of poor English-speaking skill is rooted in dual reali-

ties: the rarity of speaking activities in classes and the emphasis on formal presentations. Instead, if students could be divided into pairs, triads or small groups and speaking activities conducted outdoors, with a stress on informal communication, could lead to mastering the skill. The informal communicative competence gained in this manner is sure to help them perform better in formal contexts and not vice versa. Likewise, other skills could be mastered by resorting to the same principle.

Yet another significant aspect to trigger learning among students is employing different classroom strategies such as challenge, persuasion, competition, praise, reward, embarrassment, stimulation, and goal-setting. These must vary with individuals and even with the same student over time. If we were to cultivate the habit of productive learning in every student, a paradigm shift from generic delivery to an individualised mode is a must. Only such an approach can elevate average and mediocre students to higher levels, transforming classroom dynamics and the nature of learning. For the classroom interface to become purposeful, the central concern ought to be not how teachers teach but how learners learn.

The writer is a retired Professor of English, Anna University, and Chief Executive Chair of English Language Teachers’ Association of India (ELTAI).

Ranking for reality

The percentage-percentile conundrum in NEET

P.V. Navaneethakrishnan

A recent proposal submitted to the National Medical Commission suggested replacing the percentile-based cut-off for NEET-UG with a percentage model to decide the merit list for admissions to programmes including MBBS and BDS. Percentiles become redundant only when the same set of questions is used for all candidates, as is done in this exam. Unlike raw marks, percentiles cannot be negative; hence, they can be used to prescribe a low or even a negative cut-off eligibility mark.

Recently, after the second round of counselling for admission to PG programmes in medicine, the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences reduced the eligibility cut-off in the percentile ranking in NEET-PG for SC, ST, and OBC categories to zero (equivalent to minus 40 raw marks). The repeated relaxation of admission standards may be detrimental to the importance of the NEET-PG exam. Several academic experts have argued that a negative final score in the raw marks should be considered a disqualification, as it may indicate a lack of minimum level of competence required.



One solution could be to conduct NEET-PG at least twice a year for a higher number of eligible candidates, which in turn could allow a higher cut-off in the percentile list. Another way is to remove negative marking for wrong answers. A third option is to make candidates with negative final scores ineligible for admission and debar them from appearing for the exam for a year or two.

The Inter-se-merit of Candidates in the Information Bulletin NEET (UG)-2026 lists Physics as a tie-breaker for the same marks in Biology and Chemistry. This is redundant because the tie occurs due to the same total marks in the three subjects. Clause ‘It’ also states that the final stage will be resolved by a random process with the guidance of an independent expert committee. In fairness to students, information on this process should be part of the bulletin.

Views are personal

The writer is Former Director, Entrance Exams and Admission, Anna University, Chennai.



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

My granddaughter is in Class 11 and to wants to do Aeronautical Engineering. Which are the good institutes for this and how should she prepare? Kumar

Dear Kumar,
Aeronautical Engineering requires a strong foundation in Physics and Maths. Top institutes include IITs in Mumbai, Chennai, and Kanpur; IIST, Thiruvananthapuram; PEC Chandigarh; MIT, Manipal; and Amrita University, Coimbatore. For studies abroad, leading destinations include MIT and Stanford University in the U.S., Delft University of Technology in the Netherlands, and TUM in Germany.
Most leading colleges require JEE Advanced so specialised coaching can be helpful. Alongside, she can explore the practical side of aviation through Microsoft Flight Simulator or X-Plane. Building and flying model aircraft offers hands-on experience while learning Python or MATLAB is useful because modern aeronautics relies heavily on computer simulations.

I am doing my Bachelor’s English Language and Literature and am interested in literary and film criticism. How can I pursue this as a career? Anagha

Dear Anagha,
Build a strong digital portfolio by publishing regularly on platforms like Substack or Medium. Aim for one substantial essay a month that moves beyond reviews into criticism, connecting books or films to broader social, historical, or artistic ideas.

Map the future

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

Most universities have literary journals or film clubs. Taking on an editorial role will help you understand how writing is shaped and refined.

Literary and film criticism require different skill sets. For literary criticism, move beyond plot summaries and learn concepts such as Formalism (how a text is constructed) and Intertextuality (how texts relate to one another). Read contemporary critics to see how scholarly insight can be combined with accessible writing. For film criticism, learn the language of cinema. Develop an understanding of mise-en-scène, cinematography, sound design and major critical frameworks.

If your goal is to write for academic journals or teach, a Master’s degree or Ph.D. is often necessary. Consider programmes in Film and Screen Studies or Comparative Literature. Explore institutions such as JNU, EFLU and FTII. Fellowships and exchange programmes also support research in arts criticism.

For a stable income initially, consider complementary careers in publishing, editorial work, script consultancy, film festival programming or cultural organisations. Networking is essential. Once you have a solid body of work, apply to organisations such as the Film Critics Guild (India) or FIPRESCI. Platforms like Letterboxd and Goodreads can also help connect with fellow critics and professionals.

I am in Class 11 and want to be a commercial pilot.

What steps I should take? Manoj

Dear Manoj,
The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) requires students to have studied Physics and Maths in Class 12. Most flying academies and cadet programmes expect at least 50-55% in English, Physics and Maths. Before investing in training, ensure you are medically fit to fly. Obtain certification from a DGCA-authorised medical examiner. This includes blood tests, an ECG and eye examinations. Your vision must be 6/6, and colour blindness is a disqualifier.

There are two main routes to a Commercial Pilot Licence (CPL). The first is through a conventional flying school, where training takes about 1.5 to 3 years and costs roughly ₹45-65 lakhs. Students must complete 200 flying hours before applying to airlines. The second route is through an Airline Cadet Programme, where candidates are selected by an airline before training. These programmes are structured, usually last 18 to 24 months, and cost approximately ₹80 lakhs to ₹1.1 crores. Leading training institutes in India include IGRUA (Fursatganj), CAE Gondia (NFTI), The Bombay Flying Club, and Dunes Aviation Academy.

Focus on scoring well in Physics and Maths. If possible, visit a flying school and complete your Class 2 Medical to confirm eligibility. In Class 12, apply for your Computer Number on the DGCA Pariksha portal. After board exams, clear the DGCA ground

subjects to save time and money during flight training.

I have an ECE degree and have worked in IT. Lately I have become interested in Psychology. Is there any way I can become a clinical psychologist? Hridhaya

Dear Hridhaya,
In India, becoming a Licensed Clinical Psychologist is regulated by the Rehabilitation Council of India (RCI) and requires specific clinical training and licensing. Doing an M.A. in Clinical Psychology does not legally qualify. To work in hospitals or run a clinic, you need RCI registration.

Most Clinical Psychology programmes require a psychology background. You will need to complete a Master’s degree in Psychology first. Some universities, however, admit students from non-psychology disciplines through entrance examinations. Your background in ECE and IT can actually be a strength in emerging areas such as Computational Psychology, Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), Neuroengineering and Data Science in Mental Health.

You could also consider becoming a Counselling Psychologist. With an M.A./M.Sc. and relevant training, counsellors typically work with everyday life challenges and emotional well-being rather than severe clinical disorders.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

Govind Rammurthy

India’s education sector faces an average of 8,487 cyberattacks per week, according to data from Check Point Research (CPR) 2026. Yet, conversations with students and faculty reveal a striking disconnect: everyone knows backups matter, almost nobody maintains them. This gap between awareness and action creates an invisible crisis across Indian campuses. Research papers get lost. Dissertations disappear. Years of fieldwork evaporate. Increasingly, ransomware attackers deliberately target educational institutions primarily because their backup practices are weak and they are easy targets.

Prime targets

When Unacademy suffered a data breach in 2020, 22 million user accounts were exposed through an unsecured database. In 2023, the government-operated Diksha app leaked 1.6 million teachers’ personal information through misconfigured AWS S3 buckets. The 2022 AIMS-Delhi ransomware attack disrupted not just patient records but also medical education. Lecture materials, examination papers, and student assessment data became temporarily inaccessible during a critical academic period. All these incidents highlighted how academic institutions often have backup infrastructure weaker than mid-sized businesses.

False comfort

Most students believe they’re protected because their documents exist in Google Drive or OneDrive. This isn’t backup; it’s synchronisation. When a student accidentally deletes a file or when ransomware encrypts their local folders and those changes sync to the cloud, the “backup” becomes a perfect copy of the corrupted or deleted data.



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Save smart

Why educators and students need to back up critical academic data

Cloud platforms maintain version history, typically for 30 days. But discovering that critical academic work was accidentally overwritten usually happens during final submission chaos, often weeks after the damage occurred. By then, recoverable versions are gone.

Consider this: A final-year Engineering student lost three months of research data because their laptop hard drive failed two weeks before thesis submission. When asked, fewer than 20% of their classmates had any backup system in place for their own academic work. The response is uniform: “That’s why you should have backed up.” But nobody actually does.

Risks for educators

Faculty members accumulate even more critical data over decades: lecture materials refined over years, student grades and evaluations, research datasets that took months to collect, unpublished papers under review. Yet institutional backup policies rarely extend to individual faculty computers, creating a gap where decades of academic work exists only on ageing laptops.

In one case, a Chemistry

professor lost his exam questions because they were only on the office computer that crashed. A Humanities researcher lost interview transcripts because the backup drive sat next to the laptop that was stolen, making it not just an additional target.

The problem compounds because educators frequently work across multiple devices: office desktop, personal laptop, home computer. Important files scatter across locations with no systematic backup connecting them.

Modern ransomware doesn’t just encrypt your files; it actively hunts for backups to destroy first. Attackers spend days inside networks before deploying encryption, specifically targeting backup repositories, shadow copies, and cloud storage connections. If your backup drives are permanently connected and accessible, they’re not really backups; they’re just additional targets.

Educational institutions face a cruel calculation during placement season or final submissions: pay the ransom to recover student records immediately, or spend weeks reconstructing data while students miss critical deadlines. Many institutions

quietly pay rather than admit their backup failures.

3-2-1 rule

The solution remains straightforward: three copies of your data on two different types of media, with one copy off-site. For students and educators, this translates practically to:

Primary copy: Your working files on laptop or desktop

Second copy: Automated local backup to external drive (disconnected when not backing up)

Third copy: Cloud storage (Google Drive, OneDrive, Dropbox) with versioning

The keyword is “automated”. Manual backups fail because humans forget. Many modern security solutions include scheduled backup features as part of their anti-malware protection. Configure them once, verify quarterly, and let automation handle the rest.

Digital literacy

Perhaps the real solution is to “educate the educator” to make backup literacy as essential as plagiarism awareness or citation practices. First-year orientation should include not just college tours and integrity lectures, but practical sessions on protecting academic work. Show students how to configure automated backups. Explain why cloud sync isn’t sufficient. Demonstrate recovery procedures.

Colleges invest in learning management systems and digital libraries. Similar investment in ensuring students and faculty can actually protect the work they create would prevent far more data loss than expensive storage infrastructure. The question isn’t whether an institution will face a data loss incident. It is whether the backups will actually work when they need them.

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